

product to the viewers.

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With your scale, the revenue composition between subscription and advertising might change now. Will Jio-Cinema go pay?

We started JioCinema with everything available for free and then got premium Hollywood content, HBO and also what was made-for-Jio-Cinema, before creating a pay tier. Now, it has 18-19 million paying subscribers in five to six months. Consumers will pay if they see value.

Advertising subsidises the consumer and we will have it across platforms. We will continue to push subscription but not a one-size-fits-all solution. New-age media companies have innovated well on distribution and consumer experience, but not on monetisation models. It is time to disrupt that. We will get the optimum mix between free and behind-a-paywall.

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What will happen to linear broadcasting? Will it be a small part of a large digital-led pie?

We are very committed to its growth. When I got associated with Viacom18 and JioCinema, we had a smaller franchise and, therefore, grew digital. Now we have a very big, success-

ful and high-quality television franchise, with Star and Colors, two big brands. Linear television is still in 90 million homes at the last count. That is 300-350 million paying consumers and there are [those] using the free TV service, adding up to half a billion. What it requires is fresh energy and creativity, and we are in a position to do that.

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The big cricketing properties—IPL, BCCI and ICC—are housed in Reliance-Disney. But Disney has struggled with sports leading to financial stress...

Yes, there are some onerous financial liabilities on account of the cricket rights, and we have to solve them. It can be done by growing the market, plus innovating on advertising and monetisation. We are committed to the rights regardless of costs. Before this JV was finalised, those considerations were looked at. The bad news is cricket rights are very expensive and awarded for a very short period of time. The good news is that since they're awarded to you for that short period, you can grit your teeth and plot your way through.

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With a limited number of players now, do you



PHOTO BY **MANDAR DEODHAR**

You will need to expand the pool of advertisers, innovate, and disrupt advertising formats

expect cricket rights to reach conservative levels?

I don't know but I hope so... Cricket, or for that matter, many other rights, have become very expensive.

Cricket is a huge aggregator of viewership and a great business, provided the price is reasonable and on terms that are sensible. If that doesn't happen, then we'll have to revisit that.

I'll give you an example. Whenever I have headed businesses, I invested in movies. But there came a time when you were getting third-class movies at first-class prices. Star withdrew substantially from that and there were markets where we were still buying movies. Even at JioCinema, we invested in cricket and Hollywood content but were very selective about buying Indian movies. If